

HALO: ODS

Written by Christian O. Reyes

Adapted from the video game Halo: ODS

California Baptist University

FLM403 – Adapted Screenplay

EXT. SOMEWHERE IN THE CLOUDS — SUNSET

The heavy downpour of November rain thunders, cracks and
scorns a sky
that timbers crimson red. As the hemisphere of Ulysses
winds unleash wrath
upon clouds of ash, giving birth to hundreds of SOEIV
orbital drop pods
engulfed in flame.

Free-falling in tight formation of eighths, spiraling down
on one another
like fallen angels or preying birds.

INTERCOM

Six minutes till' contact men! Ready
yourselves.

SAM

Blessed be the Lord, my rock, who
trains my hands for war, and my
fingers for battle.

INTERCOM

Four minutes.

CONT'D SAM

He is my steadfast love and my
fortress, my stronghold and my
deliverer, my shield and he in whom I
take refuge, who subdues peoples
under me.

INTERCOM

Two.

LT. SAM RICHTER — early thirties, jaw hardened by years of
something he
cannot name — keeps his hand steady on the yoke, a rosary
clenched between
his fingers and the grip. His visor reflects a sky full of
artillery shells.

The first he avoids. Then more and more fill the sky like swarming locust, giving him mere glimpses of hindering light in an abyss of desolation and absolute darkness.

Amid the fog, comrades in their built machines sway into each other, falling like dead flies and scattered dandelions. The formation that once was — gone.

One beam ricochets off Sam's hull. Takes a chunk with it. The shockwave punches a cannonball-sized hole into the pod behind him — which explodes into bitty scraps and disappears into thin air.

INTERCOM
May-day, may-day!

SAM
Both my boosters are down. I won't be able to slow down.

INTERCOM
Evac immediately.

INT. ORBITAL DROP POD — CONTINUOUS

Below Sam's thigh: a flashing warning light, pulsing next to a card-sized photograph taped to the console. A woman. A small boy. Dark eyes. Smiling.

He stares at it for a half-second. Then snaps. He pounds his fist against the eject panel — shattering the bones of his right knuckle in the process.

A parachute rockets from the rear. With all its force it attempts to maintain stable deceleration — and fails. The momentum of gravity is merciless. The chute wraps around the pod and begins rotating.

High-end military-grade sheer metal from exterior panels tightens and squeezes.

Sam's body barely contains itself in the chair, head rocking side to side.

Knobs and screens shattering. Eardrums blistering purple until they pop and bleed.

Wind gushes through the crevices. The numbers on the dash drop.

Fast. Then faster. Then zero.

IMPACT. The pod hits pavement like a fist from God.

Sam's helmet smashes into the glass frame. G-force.

Stillness.

Then nothing.

CUT TO:

EXT. WETLANDS — NIGHT

Rain. Mud. The pod has landed on the outskirts of the battlefield, miles from their actual destination in the city of REACH.

The pod hangs above a tree. Inside, Sam is unconscious. His visor has caved in around his nose. Small pieces of glass are embedded in the pores of his cheeks. His skin and ligaments are bruised, burned, battered — beaten into an unconscious, peaceful sleep.

Two ODST soldiers arrive below. One reaches up and cuts the straps.

They lower Sam to the ground and pull him to his feet.

THOMPSON

Wake up, marine. All ground units are heading to the city. We have to go now.

CORPORAL DARNELL THOMPSON — late twenties, built wide, the kind of face

that has laughed through everything including this. He slaps Sam's cheek.

Another ODSr helps remove Sam's helmet. SERGEANT KELVIN MAREZ — mid-thirties, quiet, lean as a knife. He says nothing. He never has to.

SAM
(disoriented)
H-how far are we from here?

KELVIN
Three days. And nights.

Sam looks at the sky. Covenant dropships streak overhead in the distance.
The horizon burns orange.

He takes the rifle Thompson hands him. Checks the mag.
Chambers a round.
Looks at the photograph still tucked into his chest plate.
Looks at the burning horizon.
Moves.

CUT TO:

EXT. WETLANDS / FOREST OUTSKIRTS — NIGHT

The squad assembles in the dark. Six of them total. Sam's eyes pass over each one. Inventory.

PRIVATE LENA TORRES — medic, early twenties, small, competent, Catholic medal around her neck. She wraps Sam's broken knuckles without being asked.

CORPORAL JAMES BISHOP — radio operator, lanky, glasses beneath the visor.
His pack is heaviest. His steps the most careful.

PRIVATE FIRST CLASS RICO DIAZ — nineteen years old. The youngest. Eyes that haven't settled on anything yet. Hands that won't stop moving.

SAM

Sound off.

THOMPSON

Thompson. Two mags.

KELVIN

Marez. Three.

TORRES

Torres. Medpack's intact. Two mags,
one sidearm.

BISHOP

Bishop. Radio's functional. One mag
and I'd prefer not to use it.

DIAZ

Diaz. Four mags, sir.

SAM

Before we move. The mission. We have
a quantum bomb inbound for the
civilian bunkers beneath Reach. The
coordinates are locked. The drop was
meant to get us within striking
distance. We're behind. We move
through the wetlands, across the
basin, and into the city. We find
anyone still alive and get them out.
We find Dr. Halsey and we get her
out. We do not stop.

He looks at each face.

CONT'D SAM

Three days. And nights. Nobody sleeps
long. Nobody walks slow. Nobody
leaves anybody behind. Questions?

Silence.

THOMPSON
Yeah. Any of you all believe in God?

A beat.

KELVIN
Why?

THOMPSON
Because if we're walking into Reach,
I'd like to know who's on our side.

Sam almost smiles. Almost.

SAM
Move out.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST BASIN — DAWN

They move in file formation through a forest that smells of
plasma fire
and burnt rubber. Rain hasn't stopped. The trees here are
old but the ground
is new — scorched, cratered, wrong.

Sam walks point. Behind him, Torres wraps a bandage around
her own wrist
while walking. Bishop listens to static on his headset.
Diaz scans the
canopy constantly, restless.

DIAZ
(quietly)
Richter. Sir. How do you know
Halsey's even alive?

SAM
I don't.

DIAZ

Then why are we going to—

SAM

Because those are orders, Diaz.

DIAZ

And the civilians? Is that orders too?

Sam doesn't answer right away.

SAM

That's a choice.

Diaz nods. Keeps walking.

CUT TO:

EXT. RUINED SUBURBS — DAY ONE

What was once a neighborhood. Row houses with their faces blown out.

Family photographs still hanging on walls open to the sky. A child's bicycle half-buried under debris.

The squad moves carefully through it. Thompson clocks the bicycle.

Looks away.

Up ahead: a low COVENANT GRUNT crouches over a body, rifling through it.

Sam raises a fist. Squad stops. He gestures — single target. Kelvin nods.

Kelvin moves wide, silent. Gets behind the grunt. A single knife.

The grunt drops without a sound.

BISHOP

(scanning)

I'm picking up movement in the next three blocks. Could be a patrol.

SAM

How many?

BISHOP

Eight. Maybe ten.

SAM

We don't engage unless we have to. Go wide. Torres, you're on Diaz.

They move. But Diaz, on the far flank, rounds a corner too early.

Three Covenant GRUNTS spot him. A plasma bolt catches Diaz in the shoulder before he can drop. He goes down hard.

The rest of the squad opens up. The exchange is fast, ugly and close.

When the last grunt falls: silence except for the rain. And Diaz.

Torres is already at his side. She works fast. The rest form a perimeter.

DIAZ

(through his teeth)

I'm fine. I'm fine. Don't — I'm fine.

TORRES

You're not. But you will be if you stop moving.

She works. Sam watches. Watches the streets. Watches the smoke.

SAM

How long?

TORRES

He's mobile. The arm isn't.

DIAZ

I'm mobile. I'm fine.

THOMPSON

Kid, she said the arm isn't.

Torres finishes. Helps Diaz to his feet. He favors the arm but stands.

SAM

We don't stop again without cause.
Move.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE OPEN BASIN — NIGHT, DAY ONE

They cross miles of open ground in the dark. No conversation.

The city of Reach glows in the distance — not with lights. With fire.

Sam walks with his head down against the wind. His rosary is in his hand.

He is not praying out loud. He is counting. It is the only count that matters.

Thompson falls into step beside him.

THOMPSON

(low)

You got family in the city?

SAM

Wife. Son.

THOMPSON

How old?

SAM

Seven.

THOMPSON

He know what his dad does?

SAM

He knows I help people.

THOMPSON

That's a good answer.

A beat. Thompson looks at the burning horizon.

THOMPSON

My mom used to say God lets things
burn because he wants to see what
grows back. I always thought that was
the ugliest thing I ever heard.

SAM

And now?

THOMPSON

Now I don't know. I just keep
walking.

Sam nods. That is the right answer.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST BIVOUAC — LATE NIGHT, DAY ONE

They make camp in a stand of dense trees. No fire. Cold
rations.

Bishop monitors the radio. Torres redresses Diaz's
shoulder.

Sam sits apart, facing east. Kelvin joins him. They eat in
silence.

KELVIN

I lost a brother at the first Harvest
engagement.

Sam waits.

KELVIN

He was older. He used to say the
worst part wasn't the fighting. It
was the waiting.

SAM

Was he right?

KELVIN

I don't know. I've never learned how to wait. I just pretend I'm already moving.

Sam looks at the photograph in his hand. Tucks it away.

SAM
Get some sleep, Kelvin.

KELVIN
You too, sir.

Neither of them sleeps.

CUT TO:

EXT. BURNED HIGHWAY — DAY TWO

A six-lane highway has become a graveyard of vehicles. Cars and trucks melted to the asphalt. Some still contain their drivers.

The squad picks through it. Their boots scrape against glass and carbon.

Diaz keeps his eyes forward. Torres watches her step.

Thompson finds a portable radio under a collapsed overpass. He turns it on.

Static. Then: a child's recorded voice, looping —

RADIO
If you can hear this message, proceed to the central depot at Grid Seven. Evacuation is in progress—

Thompson turns it off. Looks at Sam.

BISHOP
That message is twelve hours old.

SAM
Then they're still there or they're already gone. Either way — we move.

Overhead: a Covenant Banshee reconnaissance craft arcs through the smoke.
The squad goes still, pressed against wreckage until it passes.

When it's gone, they breathe.

DIAZ
How many of them are there?

KELVIN
Enough.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY OUTSKIRTS — DUSK, DAY TWO

Reach. What was once a proud and densely populated city is now a wound in the earth. Buildings have been sheared at their middles. Entire blocks have been compressed into rubble.

The ODS'Ts step into the city's edge and stop. Every one of them. Just for a moment. Taking it in. Because you have to, before you can make yourself walk into it.

Mass graves along the street. Survivors have been burning them to preserve the soil. Stacks of bones sorted into piles. Children are permitted to watch, because they have no choice.

Sam moves through without looking at his feet.

EXT. CIVILIAN EVACUATION DEPOT — REACH — CONTINUOUS

At the center of a collapsed plaza: a UNSC ground crew managing a line of evacuation shuttles. Civilians press forward in thick lines.

Soldiers push them into order.

Sam scans the crowd. His face is controlled. His eyes are not.

Then — he sees her.

MARIA RICHTER — dark hair, steady eyes. She is holding the hand of

LUCAS, seven years old, in a too-large coat. They are in the line.

Sam is already moving.

THOMPSON

Richter—

Sam pushes through the crowd. Maria turns. Sees him.

MARIA

Samuel—

He reaches her and holds her — one hand on her face, one arm around her, brief and total. Lucas wraps both arms around Sam's leg.

LUCAS

Dad. Dad. I knew you'd come.

Sam kneels. Looks at his son. Grips both his arms.

SAM

I need you to listen to me. You and your mother are getting on this shuttle. You're going up. You understand?

LUCAS

Are you coming?

SAM

Not yet. I have to finish something. But I will find you. I will always find you.

The boy's face holds the weight of believing this.

MARIA
(low, urgent)
Sam. Come with us.

SAM
I can't.

MARIA
Then I'll wait for you.

SAM
You won't. You'll go. You'll go and
you won't look back.

She takes his face in both her hands. Studies it. Memorizes it.

Then nods. She takes Lucas and they move into the shuttle line.

Thompson and Kelvin stand back, watching.

THOMPSON
(quietly)
She's something, man.

Sam watches the shuttle ramp close. The engines roar.

The shuttle rises. Sam watches it go. His hands at his sides.

Rosary still wound through his fingers.

Then — a Covenant anti-air battery swings and fires. One shot.

The shuttle takes it broadside. A burst of white light. Then pieces. Then nothing.

Sam doesn't move. He watches the wreckage fall. He doesn't make a sound.

The crowd around him is screaming. He is perfectly still.

Torres takes a step toward him.

SAM
(barely audible)
Don't.

A long beat. Then he looks at Thompson. Then at the city.

SAM
Halsey. We find Halsey. We move.
He walks. They follow.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNIVERSITY DISTRICT — REACH — LATER

The university quarter was meant to be a sanctuary. It was not.

The main tower is a black skeleton. Libraries are open to the sky.

Books float in standing water.

Bishop adjusts his headset. Stops. Adjusts again.

BISHOP

I've got her signal. Sub-level three of the geology building. Forty meters north.

SAM

Movement?

BISHOP

Nothing on the surface. But the sub-levels are shielded. I can't tell.

SAM

Kelvin, Torres — cover the entrance. Thompson, Bishop — on me.

CUT TO:

INT. GEOLOGY BUILDING, SUB-LEVEL THREE — CONTINUOUS

Emergency lighting. Red. Dust thick in the air. Sample cases shattered across the floor.

A door at the end of a corridor. Sam tries it. Locked. He knocks.

A beat.

SAM

Dr. Halsey. UNSC. Open the door.

Nothing. Then — the sound of something heavy being moved from the other side.

The door opens. DR. CATHERINE HALSEY — late fifties, gray hair pulled back, spectacles cracked, hands steady. She surveys them the way a surgeon surveys a patient chart.

HALSEY

Lieutenant. You're late by approximately sixteen hours.

SAM

Yes ma'am.

HALSEY

And the rest of your unit?

SAM

Three are upstairs.

HALSEY

(noting the math)
You dropped with six.

Sam meets her eyes. Doesn't answer.

HALSEY

What is the extraction route?

SAM

West through the industrial sector.
We have a window at 0400.

HALSEY

Then we should not delay.

She picks up a satchel — heavy, careful — and follows him out.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNIVERSITY DISTRICT — NIGHT

They move in tight formation. Halsey keeps pace. She does not complain.

She observes everything — the damage patterns, the burn radii — cataloguing it all in silence.

Two blocks from the perimeter: Kelvin raises a fist.

Everyone stops.

In the shadows ahead — movement. Then the click of weapons. Covenant. A patrol. Ten at least.

KELVIN

(barely a breath)

They're between us and the exit.

SAM

Alternate route.

BISHOP

There isn't one. Not without going back through the open sector.

A beat. Sam calculates.

SAM

Kelvin. On my mark we punch through.
Fast and low. Halsey stays middle.

Halsey looks at Sam. Says nothing. Adjusts her grip on the satchel.

Sam exhales. Counts down with his fingers. Three. Two—

Before the mark — a plasma grenade lands at Torres's feet. There is one second.

Torres looks at it. Kicks it away. But not far enough.

The blast takes her off her feet. She hits the wall and doesn't get up.

The squad is immediately swarmed. Rifles knocked aside.

They're outnumbered, outflanked.
The Covenant close in.

Sam drives a fist into a grunt's face. Gets a rifle butt to the temple for it.

The world tilts. Then goes dark.

CUT TO:

INT. RUINED WAREHOUSE — NIGHT — LATER

Sam wakes to his hands bound behind him. The room smells of plasma and wet concrete. Around him: Thompson, Kelvin, Bishop, Halsey — all bound, all alive.

He looks for Torres. She is not here.

Covenant guards patrol the doorways. Grunts and JACKALS. A single ELITE stands in the center of the room, reviewing a datapad. He has not looked at them since they woke.

THOMPSON
(low)
Torres?

SAM
(lower)
I don't know.

Thompson looks at his boots. Doesn't ask again.

KELVIN
There are six guards visible. Two at the door, four rotating.

SAM
We wait.

BISHOP

For what?

SAM

Either we find a way out or something comes for us.

Halsey has been listening. She speaks without looking up.

HALSEY

This patrol is not acting on standard protocol. Their route pattern is irregular. They're waiting for something too.

KELVIN

What?

HALSEY

A superior command. Someone further up the chain who wants us processed. Which means someone wants me alive.

THOMPSON

That's good, right?

HALSEY

That depends entirely on what they want with me, corporal.

Sam closes his eyes. Not to sleep. To think.

Somewhere in the building, a sound. A distant thump. Then silence. Then another.

The guards shift. Look at each other. The Elite sets down the datapad.

Then three guards enter — and they are not Covenant. They are human. Armed. Moving fast. The firefight is sudden and brief.

When it's over, the Covenant guards are down.

VARRO steps through the door. Early forties, compact, a scar running from his chin to his left ear. He wears civilian gear modified for combat. He looks at Sam and says one word.

VARRO
UNSC?

SAM
Yes.

VARRO
Come with me.

Sam looks at him a long moment.

SAM
Insurrectionist.

VARRO
(flat, factual)
Yes. You can shoot me after we get out of here.

A beat. Sam gets to his feet. The others follow.

CUT TO:

INTERCUT — EXT. RUINS OF REACH — SIMULTANEOUS

Far from the warehouse, in a sector the humans have abandoned entirely,
a massive HUNTER ELITE moves through the wreckage of a fallen Covenant patrol. He counts the bodies. He reads the ground.

His name is VORAGG. He is enormous even by Elite standards, his armor battle-scarred, his helmet removed — a warrior's face, four-jawed and ancient.
He does not grieve. He does not rage.

He picks up a fragment of human armor from the ground. Studies it.
Sets it down. Begins to walk.

He will not stop.

CUT TO:

EXT. DEEP FOREST — BEFORE DAWN

Varro leads them through forest that has no roads and no memory of them.
He moves like he was born in it.

Sam walks beside him. They don't speak. The silence between them is not comfortable — it is honest. Two men who understand exactly what they are to each other.

SAM

How long have you been in the city?

VARRO

Four months.

SAM
Your people.

VARRO
Safe. For now.

SAM
We're going to your settlement.

VARRO
There is nowhere else.

SAM
And you trust us there.

VARRO
(a pause)
I trust that you've been in a cell
for the last six hours and you're
unarmed. Which is close enough.

Varro's two fighters return the weapons they'd taken during the rescue.
Sam checks his. Hands Thompson his rifle. Thompson bounces it once, familiar.

THOMPSON
Okay. We're even.

CUT TO:

EXT. INSURRECTIONIST VILLAGE — DAWN

They break through the trees into a clearing that should not exist.
Shelters built into the hillside. A cooking fire, enclosed and shielded.
Children running between the structures.
Chickens. A water system made from gutters and reclaimed piping.
Someone is playing a guitar.

The squad stops and stares. It is the first human sound
they have heard
in days that wasn't screaming or static.

THOMPSON
(genuine wonder)
Is that – are those people
actually...

KELVIN
Living.

THOMPSON
Yeah.

MAYA – mid-twenties, a healer's quietness – brings water to
the squad.

Thompson reaches for it. Their hands touch on the cup.
They look at each other.

It's the most alive Thompson has looked in three days.

Halsey observes the settlement with clinical precision.

HALSEY
(to Sam, quietly)
These people have been here since
before the invasion. The UNSC would
classify them as enemy combatants.

SAM
The UNSC would classify a rock as a
threat if it was in the wrong sector.

Halsey looks at him. A slight recalibration.

HALSEY
You're grieving.

Sam says nothing.

HALSEY
The shuttle.

Still nothing.

HALSEY

I'm sorry, Lieutenant.

SAM

Get some rest, Doctor.

He walks away. Finds a place at the edge of the settlement, facing the trees.

He sits. He opens his hand. The rosary.

He doesn't pray. He just holds it.

CUT TO:

INT. VILLAGE SHELTER — DAY

Thompson sits on a cot while Maya stitches the gash on his forearm.

He watches her hands.

THOMPSON

You ever leave? The village, I mean.

MAYA

Not since the invasion.

THOMPSON

You're not scared?

MAYA

I'm scared every day.

THOMPSON

But you stay.

MAYA

This is my home. Where would I go?

Thompson doesn't have an answer for that.

MAYA

Your friend. The lieutenant. His family was on that shuttle?

THOMPSON

He doesn't talk about it.

MAYA

No. I could see it in him. Some men carry their grief in their shoulders. He carries it in his eyes.

Thompson looks out toward where Sam is sitting.

THOMPSON

Yeah.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST EDGE — DUSK

Kelvin finds Varro at the edge of the settlement, watching the tree line.

He sits beside him. Pulls out a worn flask. Offers it. Varro takes it.

KELVIN

How long were you fighting the UNSC before the Covenant came?

VARRO

Eight years.

KELVIN

I was deployed against insurrectionists twice. Before this.

VARRO
(no bitterness)
I know.

KELVIN
Doesn't bother you?

VARRO
Everything bothers me. I just learned
to do things anyway.

Kelvin nods. Takes the flask back.

KELVIN
For what it's worth. My brother was
from the Outer Colonies. He talked
like you.

VARRO
You lose him?

KELVIN
First engagement.

Varro looks at him. A long moment.

VARRO
I'm sorry.

KELVIN
Me too.

They sit together and watch the dark forest.

CUT TO:

INT. RADIO SHELTER — NIGHT

Bishop has been working for hours on a cobbled-together
radio system.

Village parts. Covenant components salvaged from the ruins.
Electrical tape.

Sam watches. Halsey assists, hands steady.

BISHOP

Okay. Okay. I've got something.

Static. Then a voice – clipped, authoritative, military.

COMMAND

...identify yourself.

SAM

This is Lt. Richter, ODS unit
Whiskey-Seven. We have Doctor Halsey.
We are requesting immediate
extraction at—

COMMAND

Richter. Stand by.

A long pause.

COMMAND

Lieutenant. Your orders are to
proceed to extraction point November
with the package. Civilian assets in
your current position are not part of
the mission. Do you copy?

SAM

Command, we have approximately forty
civilians at this location. We need
extraction for all personnel.

COMMAND

Negative, Richter. Covenant forces
are converging on your sector. You
have a forty-eight hour window.
Extract the package and move to
November. Those are your orders.

Sam looks at Varro, who has heard all of it. Varro's face is a wall.

SAM
With respect, Command—

COMMAND
That is a direct order, Lieutenant.

Sam looks at Bishop. Looks at the radio. Looks at Halsey.

SAM
Copy, Command.

He reaches over and clicks off the radio.

Bishop stares at him.

HALSEY
You do understand what you've just decided.

SAM
I understand the orders I was given.

HALSEY
And you're disregarding them.

SAM
I'm going to need you to let me do that, Doctor.

A pause. Halsey looks at the silent radio. Then at him.

HALSEY
Very well.

Varro crosses his arms. He is a man who has seen promises made and broken.

VARRO

Why?

SAM

Because I put my wife and my son on a shuttle and watched it get shot out of the sky. And I am still moving. And I am still here. And I am not leaving the only people left who are worth fighting for.

Silence. Varro looks at him for a long time. Then he uncrosses his arms.

VARRO

Then we prepare.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE — NIGHT, PREPARATION

The settlement becomes a beehive. Varro briefs his fighters in their language.

The ODS Ts distribute what weapons they have.

Bishop rigs trip wires along the tree line perimeter.

Kelvin shows two village men how to load a recovered Covenant plasma rifle.

Children are moved underground into the deepest shelter.

Thompson and Maya stand at the edge of the fire's light.

MAYA

You don't have to stay.

THOMPSON

I know.

MAYA

Why?

Thompson looks at her. She is very direct. He likes that.

THOMPSON

Because somebody's gotta make sure
you're still here when this is over.

She takes his face in her hands and kisses him once. Hard.
Then lets go.

MAYA

Then don't die.

THOMPSON

Yes ma'am.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE — DEEPER NIGHT — THE WAIT

The settlement is silent. Fires banked low. Everyone in position.

The forest beyond the perimeter is absolute black.

Sam and Varro walk the line together.

VARRO

How do you keep your faith? In all of this.

SAM

I don't. Most days I just carry the habit of it.

VARRO

And tonight?

SAM

(long pause)

Tonight I just keep walking.

Varro nods. He understands that.

They stop at the far edge of the perimeter. Look out at the darkness.

Nothing moves. The forest is perfectly still.

Too still.

KELVIN

(in earpiece)

They're out there.

SAM

(quiet)

I know.

Silence. A minute. Another. The kind of silence that has weight.

In the darkness at the tree line – VORAGG pauses. He looks at the settlement.

He sees the lights. He sees the figures.

He sees everything.

He reaches down and picks up a small stone. Sets it on the ground. A marker.

He steps forward.

CRACK — a twig.

Then the wire.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE PERIMETER — CONTINUOUS

The tripwire detonates. A wall of light and heat.

And then they come.

From every angle — plasma bolts from inside the tree line,
invisible shooters
picking at the perimeter. Then the wave: GRUNTS by the
dozen, JACKALS
raising shields, ELITES pushing through the center.

The village erupts.

Sam is moving before the first body drops. Rifle up,
firing, moving.

Thompson anchors the left flank. He is surgical. Calm.

Kelvin takes the center. Varro mirrors him.

Bishop holds the radio shelter, firing from a window,
trying to get one
last signal out. Static. More static. He keeps trying.

A second wave pushes through.

A third.

Kelvin kills four Elites in sequence. He is moving to a
fifth when a plasma
sniper round catches him from the right. He drops mid-
stride, fast.
The way a candle goes out.

Sam sees it. Does not stop.

Varro falls back to cover two village fighters retreating
with the last of
the children. He holds a chokepoint between two burning
structures.
Three Elites. He takes two of them.
The third takes him.

He hits the ground and does not get up.

THOMPSON

(over comms, strained)
Richter - Bishop's down. Radio
shelter is gone.

SAM
Where are you?

THOMPSON
West shelter. Maya's in here with the
last four kids. I've got one mag and
the Covenant know where I am.

SAM
Hold it. I'm coming.

Sam fights through the courtyard. Three grunts, taken down
fast.

An Elite rushes him, too close for the rifle.
He drops it and fights with his hands - a brutal, gasping
scramble
against something bigger and stronger and alien.
He wins. Barely.

He retrieves his rifle and reaches the west shelter. Kicks
in the door.
Thompson is there. Four children and Maya pressed against
the back wall.

THOMPSON
You look terrible.

SAM
Get them into the passage.

Thompson leads Maya and the children through a trap door
into the underground.

Then - through the wall, a massive impact. Something hits
the shelter hard
enough to buckle the frame.

Voragg. He steps through the destroyed wall.

He is enormous. His armor is burned. He is completely unhurt.

He looks at Sam. He tilts his head. Something like recognition.

He swings. Sam ducks, just. Puts his rifle to the back of the Elite's knee joint — fires — nothing happens. Armor too thick.

Voragg grabs the rifle and tears it away. Throws it through the wall.

Sam is unarmed.

He backs up. Finds a piece of collapsed ceiling beam. Iron. Heavy.

He and Voragg circle each other in the burning room. What happens next is not elegant.

Sam takes three hits that should kill him. Each time he gets back up.
He uses the beam, uses the fire, uses the walls. He is not winning.
He is surviving.

Then — a moment. Voragg's armor catches on a collapsed rafter.
One second of stillness.

Sam climbs on top of him. Gets to the neck joint. Where the armor meets the helmet. The unprotected seam.

He pounds his fist into it.
Once. Twice. Three times.
Until something gives.
Until Voragg stops moving.

Sam stands over the body. He is breathing in ragged pieces. His right hand is shattered again. Blood on his face. On his chest.
The building is on fire around him.

He walks outside.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE — CONTINUOUS

Silence. The Covenant fighters are dead. The village is burning.

A handful of survivors emerge from the underground passage. Maya. Four children. Thompson helping them up.

And surrounding them — on three sides — the rest of the Covenant army.

Hundreds. Tanks. Assault carriers.

The quantum bomb threat they came here to stop is nothing compared to what is standing in front of them.

Sam stands between his people and them. Empty-handed.

He looks at Thompson. Thompson shakes his head. Last mag.

Sam looks at Halsey, who has not moved from a doorway. She returns his gaze.

He looks at the dead. Kelvin. Varro. Bishop. Torres. His whole squad. All of them.

He closes his hand around the rosary.

The Covenant army begins to move forward.

Then — from above.

A single figure descends through the smoke. MJOLNIR armor, green.

The drop is precise, controlled, devastating.

MASTER CHIEF hits the ground between the ODSs and the Covenant army.

He does not introduce himself. He does not need to.

What follows takes four minutes. During those four minutes, Sam does not move. He watches. He has seen war. He has never seen this.

When it is over — the Covenant are gone. All of them. And Chief stands there.

He turns. Walks toward Sam. Toward Halsey.

He regards the settlement. The survivors. The Insurrectionist fighters who remain.

His radio crackles.

COMMAND

Chief. Status report. Was Halsey recovered?

MASTER CHIEF

Affirmative.

COMMAND

And the location? Are there hostiles present?

Chief looks at Varro's body. At Kelvin. At the children coming up from underground.

COMMAND

Chief. That location is a known Insurrectionist settlement. Standing orders are to neutralize. Confirm.

A pause.

COMMAND

That is an order, Chief.

Chief draws his pistol. Turns to face Sam.

MASTER CHIEF

Walk away, marine.

Sam looks at the pistol. Looks at the settlement. Does not move.

SAM

No.

MASTER CHIEF

This isn't a request.

SAM

I know it isn't.

A long beat. Chief's pistol holds its line.

Then Chief turns his head slightly. Not toward Sam. Toward the ground.

At the dead ODSs laid out in the dirt. Five bodies. In their armor. In their service.

He looks at Thompson standing in front of Maya.

At an old village man on his knees, hands open, waiting.

At a child — four years old — standing in the open door of a shelter, watching him.

A very long silence.

Chief holsters the pistol.

MASTER CHIEF

(into radio)

Location is clear. No hostiles present. Proceeding to extraction with the package.

COMMAND

Copy, Chief.

He meets Sam's eyes. A beat. Then he turns away.

SAM

(quietly)

Thank you.

Chief doesn't respond. He does not need to.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE — DAWN

Sunrise. The first full light in days. It comes through the smoke strange and warm, and even this broken place looks, briefly, like something worth keeping.

An EVAC HELICOPTER descends into the clearing. UNSC. Big enough for all of them.

Halsey boards first. Deliberate, efficient. Looks back once.

Maya boards, holding the smallest child. Thompson helps the others up the ramp.

He is the last one aboard before Sam.

Sam stands at the ramp. He looks back at the settlement. The burned shelters. The dead.

He looks at Kelvin's body. Takes a long moment.

Then boards.

The helicopter lifts. Below: Chief is already walking back into the ruined city.

He does not look up.

CUT TO:

INT. UNSC FACILITY — LATER

Clean lights. The smell of antiseptic. Medical teams.
Debrief rooms.
Sam walks through it all without really seeing any of it.
A GENERAL approaches him. Older. Steady. Not unkind.

GENERAL
Lieutenant Richter.

SAM
Sir.

GENERAL
You disobeyed direct orders.

SAM
Yes sir.

GENERAL
You also recovered the package, held
a critical forward position, engaged
and neutralized a Hunter-class Elite
in direct combat, and kept your squad
alive in a three-day hostile
environment with no resupply.

Sam says nothing.

GENERAL
There is a program. You know what it
is.

SAM
Yes sir.

GENERAL
The Spartan program. You've been
recommended. After what we've seen—

SAM
I know.

GENERAL
You'd be the best soldier we've ever
made, Richter.

SAM
(quietly)
I don't want to be the best soldier
you've ever made.

The General looks at him. Studies him.

GENERAL
Then what do you want?

Sam is quiet for a moment.

SAM
Right now, sir? I want to see the
sky.

CUT TO:

INT. BRIEFING ROOM — LATER

Sam is alone. On the table before him: the new SPARTAN
SUIT, laid out.
Gleaming. Impossible in its scale.
A symbol of everything they want him to become.

He does not touch it.

He reaches into his chest plate and removes the photograph.
Creased. Bloodstained at the edge. He smooths it carefully.

But it is not Maria and Lucas this time.
It is another photograph — older. Six young men in ODST
training gear,
arms around each other. Laughing. Before everything.
Before Reach.

He recognizes every face.

Thompson. Kelvin. Bishop. Torres. Diaz. And him.

All of them smiling. All of them young. All of them gone.

Except him.

Sam sets the photograph down on the table next to the suit.
He looks at it for a long time.

Then he straightens. Rolls his shoulders. Breathes.

He reaches out. His hand – the broken one – rests on the
suit's chest plate.

He looks at the photograph once more. At every face.

Then he puts it in his pocket. Close to his heart.

And he picks up the suit.

FADE TO BLACK.

HALO: ODS

*"Somebody once wrote, hell is the impossibility of reason.
That's what this place feels like... hell."*

– Platoon (1986)

DEDICATED TO ALL WHO FELL AND WERE NOT REMEMBERED.